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Zimbabwe defeating Sri Lanka and Australia to secure Super Eight qualification at the T20 World Cup 2026 has every element of the quintessential underdog story everyone loves. But it's more than that — a story of redemption too.

Its 2026 World Cup campaign had started way back in October 2024 in Nairobi. Having missed the cut for the 2024 edition in the United States and the West Indies, Zimbabwe was the only full-member nation required to undertake the toil of the Sub-Regional Qualifiers.

In Africa, 18 teams are divided across three Sub-Regional Qualifiers, from where the top two in each advance to the Regional Finals, joined by two teams that featured in the last T20 World Cup, making it an eight-team affair. The best two teams qualify for the next edition.

Zimbabwe was at the bottom of the pile, facing Kenya, Mozambique, Rwanda, Seychelles and Gambia in Regional Qualifier B. Any team can throw a curveball in these regional tournaments and Zimbabwe was well aware of that, having lost to Uganda in the Regional Finals that cost it a place in 2024.

Renewed belief:

Zimbabwe, led by Sikandar Raza (left), could use the momentum from this tournament to revive its ODI fortunes, where it has not qualified for a World Cup since 2015. PTI